Harley-Davidson

Business Development Dossier

Industry	**Manufacturing / Consumer Products**
Revenue	**$4.5B**
Employees	**5,800**
Ideal Customer Profile Score	**91**

ICP SCORING MODEL

`ICP = Signals + Revenue + Employees + Fit   (max 100)`

Signals (0-35)	Top 4 signals scored; each = base(60%) + recency bonus <30d: 40% | <90d: 30% | <180d: 20% | older: 10%
Revenue (0-25)	$500M-$10B sweet spot -> 70-100% of 25 pts Below $500M -> pro-rata x 0.5 | Above $10B -> 60%
Employees (0-20)	2,000+ preferred (70-100%) | 500-2K partial (50-70%) Below 500 -> pro-rata x 0.3
Fit (0-20)	High-fit types: reorg, transformation, M&A, hiring, funding, partnership -> 5 pts ea (max 12) + diversity 2/type (max 8)

Prepared March 19, 2026

McChrystal Group

Leadership Advisory & Organizational Effectiveness

SECTION 1

Organization Snapshot

Legal Name	Harley-Davidson, Inc.
Headquarters	Milwaukee, Wisconsin
Founded	1903

Ownership

Public (NYSE: HOG); activist shareholder pressure from multiple institutional investors; Jochen Zeitz forced to retire as CEO

Footprint

Manufacturing in U.S. (Milwaukee, York PA, Menomonee Falls WI), Thailand, and Brazil. Global dealer network across 100+ countries. LiveWire electric motorcycle division operates semi-independently.

SECTION 1b

Company Overview

Harley-Davidson is the iconic American motorcycle manufacturer navigating a critical leadership transition with three new C-suite executives in three months: CEO Artie Starrs (Oct 2025, from Topgolf), COO Bryan Niketh (Jan 2026), and CMTO Matt Ryan (Dec 2025). Facing declining sales, activist investor pressure, and a money-losing electric vehicle bet through LiveWire, the company is conducting an end-to-end strategic review with a new plan imminent.

SECTION 2

Financial Health & Growth Stage

Understanding Harley-Davidson's financial position and trajectory is critical to framing any engagement conversation.

Revenue: ~$4.5B in 2025, declining year-over-year. Sold approximately 124,500 motorcycles, down from prior year.

Profitability: Operating margins under pressure from declining volumes; LiveWire electric division lost $75M in 2025 on just 653 units shipped. Core Harley business remains profitable but shrinking.

Analyst Sentiment: Cautious. New CEO Artie Starrs is a wildcard - his Topgolf background is unconventional for a manufacturing CEO. Street wants to see the strategic plan (expected with Q1 2026 earnings).

Key Pressures: Aging rider demographic (median age ~50); declining U.S. motorcycle market; LiveWire losses ($75M/year); tariff exposure on Thailand-built bikes; activist investors who forced prior CEO out.

Key Tailwinds: Iconic brand with massive cultural equity; new leadership team brings fresh perspective; LiveWire could be transformational if execution improves; emerging market growth potential (India, Southeast Asia).

SECTION 3

Leadership Team Profiles

The following contacts are recommended as primary outreach targets - champion-level leaders who feel the organizational pain daily and can sponsor McChrystal internally.

Bryan Niketh - Chief Operating Officer [PRIORITY TARGET]

20-year Harley-Davidson veteran; oversees Product Management, Product Development, Product Operations

Outreach rationale: The operational execution leader who must deliver on whatever strategic direction the new CEO sets. As a 20-year veteran, he bridges institutional knowledge with new leadership vision. Oversees the core product organization that must transform while maintaining quality. Natural champion for McChrystal's operating model work.

Matt Ryan - Chief Marketing & Technology Officer [PRIORITY TARGET]

Former CMO of Boyd Gaming; newly created role uniting marketing, digital, and technology capabilities

Outreach rationale: Leads a newly created role merging marketing and technology - a structural bet on digital transformation. Must unify previously separate functions while repositioning the H-D brand for younger riders. The organizational design challenge of merging these functions is a McChrystal sweet spot.

Additional leadership team members relevant to the engagement:

Artie Starrs - President & Chief Executive Officer

Former CEO of Topgolf International; grew Topgolf revenue from $1.1B to $1.8B; experience-economy leadership

Jonathan Root - Chief Financial Officer

Financial leadership during turnaround; manages cost review and capital allocation between core and LiveWire

Edel O'Sullivan - Chief Human Resources Officer [INFERRED]

People leadership during massive C-suite transition

SECTION 4

Organizational Culture & Structure

Culture and structure are often where McChrystal Group finds the deepest leverage. The following signals indicate how Harley-Davidson operates today and where friction exists.

Organizational Structure

Traditional hierarchical manufacturing organization being restructured under new leadership. Two-entity structure: Harley-Davidson Motor Company (core motorcycles) and LiveWire (electric vehicles, separately listed). New CMTO role signals move toward integrated marketing-technology function. End-to-end cost review likely to reshape organizational structure significantly.

Culture Signals

Heritage vs. Transformation Tension: Harley-Davidson's culture is deeply rooted in its 120+ year heritage, rider community, and American manufacturing identity. The arrival of a CEO from Topgolf - an entertainment company - signals a cultural pivot that will face internal resistance from employees who identify with the traditional motorcycle culture.

Leadership Whiplash: Three C-suite changes in three months (CEO, COO, CMTO) creates organizational uncertainty. Employees who survived the Zeitz era (which was itself a transformation attempt) may be exhausted from leadership churn.

LiveWire Cultural Divide: The electric motorcycle division operates with startup mentality within a legacy manufacturer - creating a 'two cultures' problem. LiveWire's $75M losses while the core business cuts costs creates resentment.

Dealer Network Resistance: Harley's 700+ independent dealers are a powerful cultural force. Any strategic shift (electric, younger demographics, experience-focused) must carry the dealer network - which has historically resisted change.

Glassdoor Signals: [INFERRED] Mixed reviews reflecting transition anxiety, loyalty to heritage brand, and uncertainty about new leadership direction.

SECTION 5

Recent News & Trigger Events

The following developments from the past 18 months create urgency and provide natural conversation entry points for engaging Harley-Davidson.

1. **2025-04-01 - CEO Jochen Zeitz announced retirement under activist investor pressure after failed transformation attempts**
   Leadership failure creates both urgency and institutional skepticism about the next transformation attempt - McChrystal must frame as operationally different, not just strategically different
2. **2025-10-01 - Artie Starrs appointed President & CEO, bringing Topgolf experience-economy background**
   Non-traditional CEO hire signals board's desire for radical culture shift - creates maximum organizational disruption and need for alignment
3. **2025-12-01 - Matt Ryan hired as first-ever CMTO, merging marketing and technology into single function**
   Structural reorganization of two previously separate functions - requires McChrystal-style cross-functional integration
4. **2026-01-01 - Bryan Niketh appointed COO; end-to-end cost review launched; new strategic plan in development**
   Operational transformation mandate from new CEO - the 90-day window where McChrystal engagement has maximum impact
5. **2026-03-01 - New strategic plan to be announced with Q1 2026 earnings (imminent)**
   Strategy announcement creates the execution challenge - 5,800 employees must align around a new direction from a CEO they barely know

6. **2025-12-01 - LiveWire shipped just 653 electric bikes in 2025, losing $75M; company doubled investment despite losses**

   Electric pivot is a strategic bet that defies current results - requires organizational conviction and coordination that doesn't yet exist

SECTION 6

McChrystal Fit Assessment

> *Three C-suite changes in three months = acute organizational alignment need. New CEO from outside industry = cultural bridge-building required. Declining sales + activist pressure = urgency. Revenue $4.5B = budget exists for premium advisory. The window between strategy announcement and execution is precisely when McChrystal creates maximum value. LiveWire's 'startup within a manufacturer' is a Team of Teams challenge.*

Primary Problem

A new CEO (from an entirely different industry) must align a 120-year-old heritage organization behind a new strategic direction, execute an end-to-end cost restructuring, and decide the future of a money-losing electric vehicle division - all while facing activist investors, a declining core market, and an aging customer base.

Best McChrystal Capability Fit

Crisis leadership and organizational transformation - Harley-Davidson is in a turnaround situation where the new leadership team must build trust, create shared consciousness, and execute at speed in a culture that has historically resisted change. McChrystal's experience transforming hierarchical, tradition-bound organizations (military) into agile, adaptive teams is the direct analog.

Likely Objections to Engagement

New CEO wants to establish his own direction before bringing in advisors
Cost review means advisory budgets are being cut, not expanded
Prior CEO (Zeitz) already tried transformation and failed - skepticism about external help
McChrystal's military background may not resonate with the rider/lifestyle culture

Competitive Advisory Landscape

BCG or McKinsey - likely advising on strategic review and cost restructuring
AlixPartners - turnaround and restructuring specialist, possible engagement
Bain & Company - consumer products and brand strategy expertise
Korn Ferry - leadership assessment for new C-suite effectiveness

SECTION 7

Conversation Entry Points

These questions are designed for a Senior Partner's first conversation. Each opens a thread that naturally leads to McChrystal Group's capabilities without a direct pitch.

1. With three new C-suite executives in three months, how is the new leadership team building shared operating norms while simultaneously developing the strategic plan?

Acknowledge the specific challenge of a new leadership team that must both bond and deliver simultaneously - McChrystal's team-building under pressure methodology.

2. How are you thinking about aligning 5,800 employees behind a new strategic direction from a CEO who's been here less than 6 months - especially when the last transformation attempt didn't land?

Address the institutional skepticism head-on - show awareness that this isn't Harley's first transformation attempt and that execution, not strategy, is the differentiator.

3. The CMTO role merging marketing and technology is a bold structural bet. How is the integration going - and what's been harder than expected?

Show interest in a specific organizational design decision that Matt Ryan is living daily - creates a natural entry for McChrystal's cross-functional integration expertise.

Recommended Meeting Framing

Frame as a brief conversation about what McChrystal has learned from heritage organizations (military, manufacturing, century-old institutions) that successfully transformed without losing the culture that made them iconic. The parallel between military tradition and Harley heritage is genuine and resonant.

SECTION 8

Brand Insights & Market Positioning

Brand strategy reveals organizational priorities and coordination challenges. The following analysis connects Harley-Davidson's market positioning to potential McChrystal engagement opportunities.

Brand Value: Harley-Davidson is one of the most recognized brands in the world - a $4.5B company with cultural equity that far exceeds its market cap. The H-D logo is tattooed on more human bodies than any other corporate brand. This is both the company's greatest asset and its greatest constraint: any transformation must honor the heritage while attracting new riders.

Brand Identity Evolution: Under Zeitz, Harley attempted a lifestyle/fashion pivot ('More Roads to Harley-Davidson') that alienated core riders without fully attracting new ones. New CEO Starrs must find a brand positioning that bridges heritage riders and younger demographics - a challenge that has defeated multiple prior attempts.

Marketing Leadership: The newly created CMTO role (Matt Ryan) signals that brand and technology are being unified. Ryan's Boyd Gaming background suggests an experience/engagement focus rather than traditional product marketing. This is a significant organizational bet.

Brand Threats: Aging rider demographic (median age ~50); Japanese and European competitors gaining share in younger demographics; electric vehicle brands (Zero, Energica) establishing identity before LiveWire; cultural polarization of the brand (some view H-D as exclusionary rather than aspirational).

Major Brand Investments: LiveWire is the biggest brand bet - creating a sub-brand for electric that's distinct enough to attract new riders but connected enough to leverage H-D heritage. The $75M annual loss is effectively a brand investment. Stadium sponsorships, rally events (Sturgis), and dealer experience centers are other major brand touchpoints.

McChrystal Connection: The brand transformation requires every part of the organization to execute consistently - manufacturing must build products that match the brand promise, dealers must deliver experiences that reinforce it, LiveWire must innovate without diluting it. This is a coordination challenge across manufacturing, retail, marketing, and product development that McChrystal's operating model addresses.

SECTION 9

Deep McChrystal Group Fit Analysis

This is the strategic case for pursuing Harley-Davidson. It synthesizes findings from all previous sections into a comprehensive engagement thesis with specific fit dimensions, expected outcomes, stakeholder mapping, and a phased pursuit strategy.

9a. Fit Dimensions

Fit Dimension 1: New Leadership Team Cohesion Under Pressure

Three C-suite executives joining in three months must build trust, shared language, and operating norms while simultaneously developing and launching a new strategic plan. McKinsey provides the strategy; McChrystal builds the leadership team that can execute it. The CEO (from entertainment), COO (20-year H-D veteran), and CMTO (from gaming) bring radically different perspectives - valuable for innovation, risky for alignment. McChrystal's team-building methodology turns this diversity into an asset rather than a friction source.

Fit Dimension 2: Heritage Organization Transformation

Harley-Davidson's 120+ year culture is simultaneously its greatest asset (brand equity, employee loyalty, dealer passion) and its greatest barrier to change. Prior transformation attempts failed because they tried to override the culture rather than evolve it. McChrystal's military experience - transforming tradition-bound organizations while respecting their heritage - is the direct analog. No strategy firm replicates this cultural sensitivity.

Fit Dimension 3: Dual-Entity Coordination (Core + LiveWire)

Harley operates two entities with fundamentally different cultures, timelines, and success metrics: a profitable-but-declining core motorcycle business and a money-losing-but-strategic electric vehicle division. Coordinating resource allocation, talent movement, technology transfer, and brand management between these entities requires the kind of cross-unit coordination McChrystal's Team of Teams model provides.

Fit Dimension 4: Dealer Network Alignment

700+ independent dealers are not employees - they're autonomous operators who must be persuaded, not directed. Any new strategic direction requires dealer buy-in to execute. McChrystal's decentralized authority model (empower execution at the edge, align on intent) maps directly to the franchise/dealer coordination challenge.

9b. Cumulative Case - Why Harley-Davidson Is a Top Pipeline Opportunity

Harley-Davidson is a once-in-a-generation transformation story: an iconic brand that must reinvent itself or face secular decline. The signal chain: Aging demographic -> declining sales -> activist pressure -> CEO forced out -> new CEO from different industry -> three C-suite changes in 90 days -> end-to-end cost review -> new strategic plan -> 5,800 employees waiting for direction. Each signal amplifies the organizational complexity. The 90-day window between strategy announcement and execution launch is the highest-leverage moment for McChrystal engagement.

Revenue Potential: $400K-$500K initial engagement (leadership team alignment + strategy execution architecture), expandable to $1.5M-$2M for enterprise transformation including dealer network alignment, with $300K-$500K ongoing for execution cadence management. Total: $2M-$3M over 18-24 months.

9c. Enterprise Issues & Organizational Challenges

1. Leadership Team Integration Speed: CEO (6 months tenure), COO (3 months), CMTO (4 months) must function as a cohesive unit while each is still learning the organization. The risk of parallel decision-making without alignment is acute.

2. Strategy-Execution Gap from Prior Transformation: Zeitz's transformation had good strategic logic but failed in execution. Employees are conditioned to hear 'new strategy' and wait it out. Starrs must prove this time is different - which requires visible execution discipline, not just compelling strategy.

3. Core vs. LiveWire Resource Conflict: LiveWire's $75M loss competes with core business cost reduction for capital and leadership attention. Every dollar invested in electric is a dollar not returned to shareholders or invested in the profitable core - creating internal political tension.

4. Dealer Network Skepticism: 700+ independent dealers survived prior transformation attempts by waiting them out. They will apply the same approach unless the new strategy includes a compelling dealer value proposition and execution partnership model.

5. CMTO Function Integration: The newly created Chief Marketing & Technology Officer role merges two previously separate organizations with different cultures, skills, and success metrics. Matt Ryan must build a unified team while also delivering on both marketing and technology mandates.

6. Manufacturing Flexibility Gap: Harley's U.S. manufacturing base (high cost, unionized) must adapt to new product strategies while managing tariff exposure on Thailand-built bikes. The tension between heritage ('Made in America') and economics (global manufacturing efficiency) is an organizational design challenge.

7. Generational Brand Relevance: Attracting riders under 35 without alienating riders over 50 requires different products, marketing, dealer experiences, and community strategies - essentially running two customer strategies simultaneously.

9d. Expected Outcomes from McChrystal Group Engagement

1. Leadership Team Operating Rhythm: Design and implement the operating cadence for the new C-suite - shared decision-making framework, information flow architecture, and weekly alignment mechanism. Measurable: reduce strategic decision cycle time from weeks to days.

2. Strategy Execution Architecture: Build the organizational machinery that translates Starrs' strategic plan into

aligned execution across all functions. Measurable: 90%+ of strategic initiatives on-track at 90-day review.

3. Core-LiveWire Coordination Model: Design the dual-entity operating model that coordinates resource allocation, technology transfer, and brand management between core and electric. Measurable: eliminate resource allocation conflicts and reduce escalations by 60%.

4. Dealer Network Alignment Program: Develop the decentralized alignment model that carries 700+ independent dealers through the strategic transition. Measurable: 80%+ dealer participation in new strategic programs within 12 months.

5. CMTO Function Integration: Accelerate the merger of marketing and technology into a unified function under Matt Ryan. Measurable: unified operating cadence established within 90 days; cross-functional project delivery on-time rate >85%.

6. Transformation Credibility: Build the visible execution discipline that overcomes institutional skepticism from failed prior transformations. Measurable: employee confidence in strategic direction (survey) improves 20+ points within 6 months.

9e. Key Stakeholders & Business Unit Map

Harley-Davidson Motor Company

Leader: Artie Starrs, CEO
Function: Core motorcycle business, overall strategy
McChrystal Relevance: Executive sponsor; new to company and industry

Operations / Products

Leader: Bryan Niketh, COO
Function: Product mgmt, development, manufacturing
McChrystal Relevance: Priority: Operational execution leader, institutional bridge

Marketing & Technology

Leader: Matt Ryan, CMTO
Function: Unified marketing + digital + technology
McChrystal Relevance: Priority: New function integration; brand transformation

LiveWire

Leader: [Division leadership TBD]
Function: Electric motorcycles, separate public entity
McChrystal Relevance: Dual-entity coordination challenge

Finance

Leader: Jonathan Root [INFERRED], CFO
Function: Cost review, capital allocation, investor relations
McChrystal Relevance: Controls advisory budget; manages activist expectations

Human Resources

Leader: Edel O'Sullivan [INFERRED], CHRO
Function: Talent, culture, organizational design
McChrystal Relevance: Change management during leadership transition

Dealer Network

Leader: [VP/SVP Dealer Operations]
Function: 700+ independent dealers globally
McChrystal Relevance: Decentralized alignment challenge

Stakeholder Engagement Priority:

1. Bryan Niketh (COO) - operational leader, institutional knowledge, execution mandate
2. Matt Ryan (CMTO) - function integration challenge, brand transformation
3. Artie Starrs (CEO) - executive sponsor, open to new approaches given his non-industry background
4. CHRO - change management and cultural transformation

9f. Opportunity Thesis

Strategic Signal Convergence - Why Now: Aging demographics -> declining sales -> activist pressure -> CEO ousted -> new CEO from entertainment industry -> COO and CMTO hired -> end-to-end cost review -> new strategic plan (imminent) -> 5,800 employees + 700 dealers awaiting direction. The convergence is unprecedented in Harley's 120-year history. The 30-60 day window after strategy announcement is the highest-leverage moment - when execution discipline determines whether this transformation attempt succeeds where prior ones failed.

The Structural Paradox - Why McChrystal, Not McKinsey: BCG or McKinsey will develop the strategic plan. AlixPartners may advise on cost restructuring. Bain may help with brand strategy. But Harley's problem is not strategy - it's execution in a culture that has defeated multiple prior strategies. McChrystal's unique value: transforming tradition-bound organizations (JSOC -> Harley) without destroying the heritage that creates their competitive advantage. No strategy firm can credibly claim this capability.

Phased Engagement Hypothesis - Land and Expand:

- Phase 1 (Months 1-3, $400K-$500K): New Leadership Team Alignment - facilitate rapid trust-building and shared operating norms for Starrs/Niketh/Ryan; design the strategy execution architecture for the new plan rollout. Beachhead: the leadership team itself - visible, high-impact, and the CEO needs it whether he knows it or not.
- Phase 2 (Months 4-9, $800K-$1.2M): Enterprise strategy execution deployment across operations, CMTO function integration, and dealer network alignment. LiveWire coordination model.
- Phase 3 (Months 10-18, $300K-$500K retainer): Ongoing execution cadence management, quarterly strategic reviews, dealer network transformation program.

Competitive Displacement Strategy: Don't compete with BCG on strategy or AlixPartners on cost. Position McChrystal as: "The strategy is the easy part. Executing it in a 120-year-old culture with a brand-new leadership team and skeptical employees/dealers - that's where transformations succeed or fail." Enter through COO or CMTO who feel the execution gap daily.

Multi-Threaded Pursuit Map:

- Thread 1: Bryan Niketh (COO) - operational execution. Angle: "How are you building the execution architecture for the new strategy when you've been COO for just 3 months?" Appeal: 20-year veteran who knows the culture and wants the new CEO to succeed.
- Thread 2: Matt Ryan (CMTO) - function integration. Angle: "How is the marketing-technology merger going - and what's the organizational friction between the two cultures?" Appeal: he's in a newly created role with no playbook.
- Thread 3: Artie Starrs (CEO) via McChrystal personal network - entertainment/sports industry connections (Topgolf, experiential brands). Military parallel: "General McChrystal transformed a 200-year-old institution (the U.S.

military) without destroying its heritage. Your challenge is similar."

- Warm Introduction Vectors: McChrystal personal network in experiential brands/entertainment; board connections; veteran connections among Harley leadership or rider community; Sturgis Rally or H-D dealer conference proximity.